Echoes of Poetry: Recontextualizing Classical Chinese Poetry into Modern Pop Music through Narrative Visualization

Yechun Peng
Tongji University
Shanghai, China
Intelligent Big Data Visualization Lab
Shanghai, China
pengyechun0406@gmail.com

Xin Chen
Tongji University
Shanghai, China
Intelligent Big Data Visualization Lab
Shanghai, China
2353547@tongji.edu.cn

Dianheng Jiang
Tongji University
Shanghai, China
Intelligent Big Data Visualization Lab
Shanghai, China
jayden0211@163.com

Hanyu Dong
Tongji University
Shanghai, China
Intelligent Big Data Visualization Lab
Shanghai, China
2353394@tongji.edu.cn

Nan Cao
Tongji University
Shanghai, China
Intelligent Big Data Visualization Lab
Shanghai, China
nan.cao@gmail.com

Yang Shi
Tongji University
Shanghai, China
Intelligent Big Data Visualization Lab
Shanghai, China
shiyang1230@gmail.com

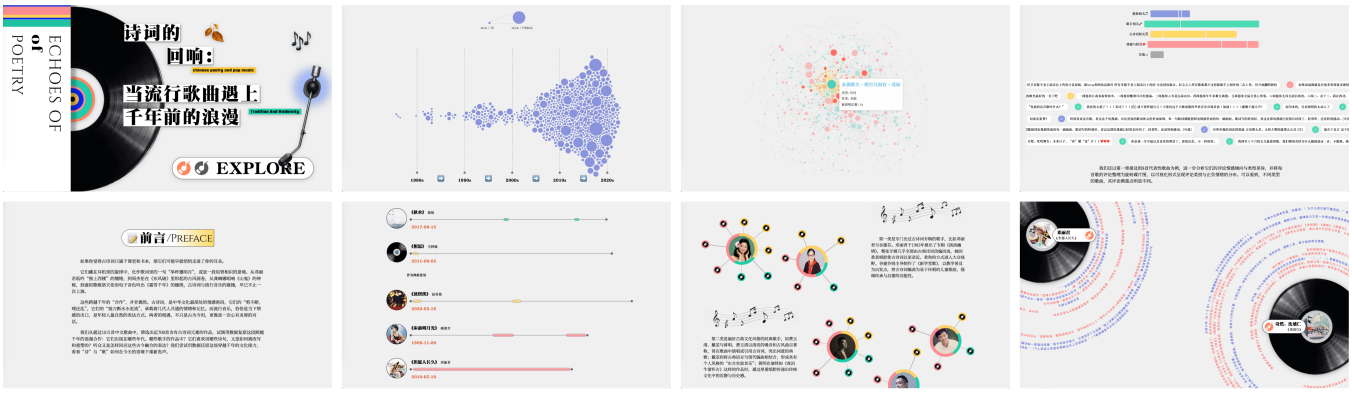

Figure 1: An overview of *Echoes of Poetry*, including representative visualizations of (a) Cover and Preface, (b) Chapter One, (c) Chapter Two, and (d) Chapter Three.

Abstract

In digital humanities research, recontextualizing traditional culture into contemporary contexts supports cultural revitalization and fosters deeper public understanding, and visualization serves as a bridge in this process. Our work, *Echoes of Poetry*, presents an interactive narrative visualization that maps how classical Chinese poetry is quoted, adapted, and transformed in over 600 modern pop songs. By analyzing lyrics content, artist preferences, and audience responses, the project reveals how classical poetry recontextualization gains renewed meanings and emotional resonance, revitalizing its role in contemporary popular culture. It demonstrates how visualization enables cultural reinterpretation and bridges classical contents with modern expressive media.

ACM Reference Format:
Yechun Peng, Xin Chen, Dianheng Jiang, Hanyu Dong, Nan Cao, and Yang Shi. 2025. Echoes of Poetry: Recontextualizing Classical Chinese Poetry into Modern Pop Music through Narrative Visualization. In *SIGGRAPH Asia 2025 Posters (SA Posters '25), December 15–18, 2025, Hong Kong, Hong Kong*. ACM, New York, NY, USA, 3 pages. https://doi.org/10.1145/3757374.3771460

1 Introduction

Visualization has become a significant medium in digital humanities, particularly for presenting data on traditional culture, such as classical literature [Peng et al. 2024], historical events [Davis and Kräutli 2015], and architectural artifacts [Issini 2012]. As traditional culture is often seen as a distant and static legacy, visualization tends to document and reproduce the original form of artifacts or texts, with limited attention to recontextualization and reinterpretation across historical periods and audiences. Yet visualization is not merely a tool for data showing. By integrating multidimensional

Permission to make digital or hard copies of all or part of this work for personal or classroom use is granted without fee provided that copies are not made or distributed for profit or commercial advantage and that copies bear this notice and the full citation on the first page. Copyrights for third-party components of this work must be honored. For all other uses, contact the owner/author(s).

SA Posters '25, Hong Kong, Hong Kong

© 2025 Copyright held by the owner/author(s).

ACM ISBN 979-8-4007-2134-2/25/12
https://doi.org/10.1145/3757374.3771460

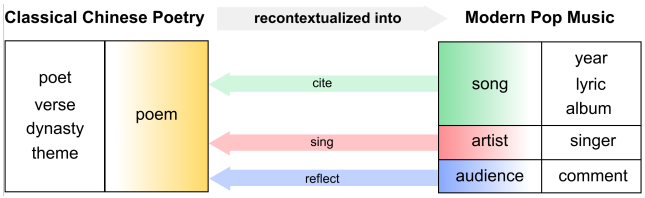

Figure 2: The dimensions and structure of dataset.

data, interaction, and narration, it enables open, participatory recontextualization across cultural boundaries. In this light, Hinrichs et al. [Hinrichs et al. 2019] introduced the concept of "visualization as mediator," emphasizing its potential to facilitate recontextualization by fostering participatory access, critical reflection, and cross-cultural dialogue. In this work, we use interactive narrative visualization to explore how classical Chinese poetry is recontextualized in modern pop music, through the lenses of data, narrative, and visual design. Our findings show that classical poetry, as a vital medium of traditional culture, is reshaped when embedded in pop lyrics, through forms more aligned with contemporary aesthetics and communicative contexts, enhancing its resonance with modern audiences. Moreover, integrating classical poetry into pop music enriches the lyrics with deeper cultural meaning and emotional complexity. It can be accessed at https://musicpoetry.github.io/.

2 Implementation

We recontextualized classical Chinese poetry within modern pop music through three dimensions: data, narrative, and visual design.

2.1 Data Recontextualization

At the data level, we built a corpus to support recontextualization by structurally linking two previously independent datasets. We aligned a lyrics dataset of over 100,000 pop songs with a Chinese poetry dataset through text matching. We then scraped metadata of songs from Netease Music, including singer, release year, album, and user comments. After cleaning and preprocessing, we identified 680 representative pop songs that explicitly use classical poetry in lyrics and have over 50 comments. The data dimensions and structure are shown in Figure 2, as it formed the basis for cross-contextual analysis.

2.2 Narrative Recontextualization

At the narrative level, we analyzed how classical poetry is embedded within the context of pop music from three perspectives, focusing on how poetry enriches pop culture and how pop music revitalizes poetry for contemporary audiences.

From Verse to Voice: Poetry in Pop Lyrics. We examined the temporal distribution, frequency, and citation strategies of classical poetry in pop songs, identifying three types: "fragment collaging", "line embedding," and "full-text reproduction". These verses are reorganized within melodies to convey new meanings, transforming literary text into musical and emotional expression. This demonstrates a direct instance of textual recontextualization.

Figure 3: Disks and playback bar as metaphors of visualization.

From Page to Stage: Artists as Cultural Mediators. We explored connections between artists and cited poetry through network analysis. Different genres exhibited distinct citation preferences and creative strategies. Recontextualization closely aligns with personal style, artistic tendency, and cultural identity construction. For content creators, classical poetry serves as both a cultural asset and an expressive tool, while artists act as mediators to reinterpret its connotation.

From Sound to Self: Audience for Meaning-Making. We conducted sentiment and thematic analysis of user comments, finding that many expressed emotional resonance and renewed interpretations of poetic imagery. Listeners used comment spaces to articulate experiences and identification, actively reassigning meaning to classical poetry in modern contexts. This audience-driven process contributes to the revitalization of traditional culture among younger generations.

2.3 Visual Recontextualization

At the visual level, our design challenges the conventional link between traditional culture and classical style by adopting a pop visual language rooted in modern culture. The interface employs flat design, vibrant color schemes, and icons like emojis to echo pop music's emotional expressiveness and rhythm. We also incorporated imagery such as disks and playback bars to align with pop music semantics, as shown in Figure 3, embedding poetry within modern visual metaphors that grant classical content a concrete presence in popular culture.

3 Summary and Future Work

This project uses interactive narrative visualization to examine how classical Chinese poetry is recontextualized in pop music. By analyzing lyrics, artists, and audience responses, we reveal how classical poetry circulates in modern expressive contexts and gains renewed vitality through contemporary visualization. Future work will extend poetic recontextualization across disciplines and media to explore its cross-cultural potential. We also plan to explore how emerging forms, such as video, animation, and AR/VR, can enhance the dissemination and immersive experience of classical poetry in modern culture.

Acknowledgments

Yang Shi is the corresponding author.

References

Stephen Boyd Davis and Florian Kräutli. 2015. The idea and image of historical time: Interactions between design and digital humanities. *Visible Language* 49, 3 (2015).

Uta Hinrichs, Stefania Forlini, and Bridget Moynihan. 2019. In defense of sandcastles: Research thinking through visualization in digital humanities. *Digital Scholarship in the Humanities* 34, Supplement_1 (2019), i80–i99.

Giovanni Issini. 2012. Knowledge Visualization of large-size architectural heritage. A research experience on Yanqing Section of Chinese Great Wall. In *2012 16th International Conference on Information Visualisation*. IEEE, 523–527.

Yechun Peng, Jingxin Ye, Dianheng Jiang, Qing Chen, Yang Shi, and Nan Cao. 2024. Starry Starry Night: An Interactive Narrative Visualization of Astrology Imagery in Tang Poetry. In *ACM SIGGRAPH 2024 Posters*. 1–2.